

WHY DO MEMORIES FADE?

Everyone enjoys a trip down memory lane. Reminiscing about happy moments and special times of life keeps the past alive in our minds. Yet some recollections are so vivid that it feels as if they happened only yesterday, while others are so hazy that any details are difficult to remember. All of our experiences leave an impression on the brain whether we realize it or not, but the strong emotions associated with significant events make these memories easier to recall.

MEMORY LANE



FORGET IT!

An elephant never forgets, but people often do. This shouldn't be viewed as a negative thing, though. Forgetting is as essential as remembering. If your brain didn't filter through the information it receives, your memory would go into overdrive. Minor details would fill your brain, blocking your ability to think clearly. The brain takes control, cherry picking the most interesting and memorable information and getting rid of the rest. That's why the moments that are less meaningful and relevant to us are more difficult to recall.

PROCESSING MEMORIES

The first three years of your life are probably virtually blank on the memory front, but after this time, the brain starts to record memories. It does not have a specific place where information and experiences are stored like a memory bank. Instead, there is a seahorse-shaped area of the brain called the hippocampus that plays an important part in memory. This is where short-term memories first go to be processed, before being turned into long-term memories. No amount of memory jogging can help some people remember the recent or distant past. This condition is called amnesia, and it occurs if the hippocampus suffers damage.

MEMORY TYPES

There are different types of memory, and these are used at different times. Certain things are not worth remembering, as they were useful only in that second, such as memorizing a train's track number on a departure board. Once you are on the train, this information does not need to be saved in the brain. Other moments are unforgettable. A landmark birthday may stay in your mind throughout the course of your life because it was so special to you.

LONG-TERM

This type of memory can last a lifetime. Moments that provoke the strongest emotions, such as great joy or sadness, stick in the brain. Weddings, births, and funerals are among the most common examples of long-term memories. Procedural is another type of long-term memory in which a skill or talent is repeated so many times that it is never forgotten.

